

Practice Paper 1 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Attitude before the hike

Award **1 mark** for identifying overconfidence / complacency; **1 mark** for explaining the link to her past experience.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the narrator was **overconfident** and **complacent**, because she believed that her past familiarity with the trail meant she did not need to take any new precautions.

Q2. [2] — Two details hinting at bad weather

1 mark each for any two of:

- The sky was “the colour of polished steel” (suggesting an overcast / metallic sky).
- The sun was “pale” and hanging “listlessly” (suggesting weak and ineffective light).
- The sun was “neither warming the air nor lighting it properly.”
- The narrator was wearing only “a thin fleece” with “a half-empty water bottle” (implying she has not prepared for cold).

Reject: “the forecast had promised a clear afternoon” — this is the opposite of a hint.

Q3. [2] — Wind as a living creature

1 mark for identifying that the wind has been given human / animal qualities (**personification**); **1 mark** for explaining the **progression** from “whisper” to “sigh” to “snarl”, which makes the wind seem to grow angrier or more threatening like a living thing.

Sample answer: The wind is **personified**: it is given the human action of whispering and sighing, and the animal action of snarling. The escalation from a gentle whisper to an angry snarl makes it feel as though the wind itself is a living creature whose mood is darkening into hostility.

Q4. [2] — “Gentle and useless garment”

1 mark — **Unusual:** Clothing is not normally described using human qualities such as “gentle”; the word usually describes a person’s character.

1 mark — **Suggestion:** The narrator is **mocking herself** / **expressing bitter regret** that she chose such a soft, inadequate item for a serious hike — it underlines how poorly prepared she was.

Q5. [2] — The father’s voice

(a) [1]: It suggests the narrator is reaching for a **trusted, authoritative voice from her past** at a moment of fear; her father represents safety, common sense, and protection that she does not currently have.

(b) [1]: It suggests she is **fully aware** of her foolishness already and does not need the criticism to be spoken aloud — the realisation is **deeply painful and self-evident**.

Q6. [3] — Hostile mountain (language question)

1 mark for identifying **personification** / hostility; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “a moody, irritable stranger” — gives the mountain a human bad temper, making it seem unpredictable.
- “muttered around my ears” — the verb **muttered** suggests low, threatening human speech, as though the mountain is grumbling at her.
- “tried, every few steps, to push me over” — the verb **push** suggests deliberate, physical aggression.
- “twice I went down hard on my knees” — the mountain inflicts injury (her bloody palm), reinforcing its hostility.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “The storm had eaten time”

1 mark for understanding that the narrator has **lost her sense of how much time has passed**;

1 mark for the **metaphor**: the storm is so consuming and overwhelming that it has **swallowed up** / **devoured** her ability to perceive time normally.

Q8. [1] — “Absurd neatness”

1 mark: The word “absurd” suggests the narrator finds the neatness **strangely out of place** / **almost laughable** given the chaos of the storm — it underlines the **contrast** between the violence outside and the quiet kindness of the stranger who folded the blanket. (Also accept: it shows her **relief** expressed through dark humour.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence of physical shock

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “shivering so violently that I bit my tongue and tasted iron”.
- She “did not trust [her] hands not to drop” the candle.
- Her breathing had not yet slowed.

Q10. [2] — “A tedious companion on a hill”

1 mark — She has become **cautious** / **overly careful** / **methodical**: she now packs equipment, tells people her route, and double-checks her gear.

1 mark — The word **tedious** shows she accepts that this caution is **boring** to others, but she values **safety over excitement** now.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective**, **humbled**, **cautious**, **sobered**, **reverent**. (Reject: **sad**, **angry** — these miss the contemplative quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A small civic ritual”

1 mark for understanding **civic** — relating to the community / public life.

1 mark for understanding **ritual** — a regular, almost ceremonial practice.

Together: the bookshop window was a **regular, shared community practice** through which the shop **participated in the cultural life** of the neighbourhood.

Q13. [2] — Economic advantage of online retailers

1 mark each for any two of:

- Online retailers can **stock more titles** than a physical shop.
- They **deliver in less than a day**.
- They use **bulk purchasing** and **slim margins** to **charge lower prices** than independents can afford.
- E-books cost almost nothing to stock and weigh nothing to ship.

Q14. [2] — The “curious” situation

1 mark — Independent bookshops are **closing** (and so the standard story of decline appears true).

1 mark — Yet at the same time, new independent bookshops are **opening, often in the same year and on the same street** — so the industry is **simultaneously dying and reviving**.

Q15. [2] — Books as a commodity

1 mark: A **commodity** is an interchangeable, mass-produced object whose value lies only in its physical content; one copy of a book is the same as another.

1 mark: Because online retailers excel at selling identical, interchangeable items at scale, bookshops **cannot win** a competition based purely on the **object** — they must offer something else.

Q16. [2] — “Whispered, with a wry half-smile”

1 mark — **Whispered** suggests **intimacy**, a private, personalised recommendation, the opposite of a public algorithm.

1 mark — **Wry half-smile** suggests **gentle humour and human insight** — the bookseller understands the reader as a person, not as a data point.

Q17. [2] — Effect of “This is not nostalgia.”

1 mark — The **short, blunt sentence** contrasts sharply with the more lyrical preceding paragraph and signals a **shift in tone** from feeling to evidence.

1 mark — It **pre-empts the reader’s objection** — that the writer is being sentimental — and prepares the reader for the **factual, statistical** argument that follows.

Q18. [2] — A shelf vs a search bar (own words)

1 mark — A **physical shelf** displays many books at once; the reader's eye is **drawn naturally** to titles they were not looking for.

1 mark — A **search bar** shows the reader only what they already know they want; it **narrows** rather than **broadens** attention.

Reject answers that lift “forces the eye to wander” without rewording.

Q19. [2] — Bookshop as democratic public space

1 mark each for any two of:

- It requires **no purchase** to enter.
- It carries **current debates and new titles** (unlike a library / museum).
- It does **not insist on a hush** (i.e. it is informal).
- It **welcomes everyone equally** — a child in school uniform, a retired teacher, a tourist.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “a salary no reasonable accountant would recommend”

1 mark — **Wry / dryly humorous / gently ironic**. (Also accept: **affectionate, bittersweet**.
Reject: **sarcastic, bitter**.)

Q21. [2] — “A new and rather hardier creature”

1 mark — Describing a **shop** as a **creature** is a **metaphor / personification**; it makes the shop feel **alive, evolving, and capable of struggle and survival**.

1 mark — **Hardier** emphasises **toughness and adaptability** — this new species of bookshop has **evolved** to survive harsher conditions than the old high-street model.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

What makes a good independent bookshop different (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. It offers **curated selection / personal recommendation** (rather than a mere catalogue).
2. It provides **atmosphere** / a physical browsing experience that algorithms cannot replicate.
3. Customers buy **more books per year** and read **across a wider range of genres**.
4. **Physical browsing** exposes the reader to many **unintended** discoveries — books they had not searched for.
5. The shop functions as a **democratic public space** / accessible to all visitors regardless of purchase or background.

What challenges independent bookshops face (Paragraph 6):

6. **Thin profit margins** — the business is financially precarious.
7. **Rising rents**, especially in city centres.
8. Many shops rely on a **partner's income, a landlord's goodwill**, or owners taking a **very low salary** / they must **diversify** (cafes, events, gifts) to stay afloat.

Sample full-marks summary (76 words):

Unlike an online retailer, a good independent bookshop offers expert curation, a welcoming atmosphere, and personal recommendations that machines cannot match. Its customers buy more titles each year and read across wider genres, while physical shelves expose them to books they

would never have searched for. The shop also acts as an open community space. However, such shops endure narrow margins, climbing rents and modest pay, often surviving only by hosting events or adding cafes.

Length count: 76 words from “Unlike” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —